

taste buds but will nonetheless attempt to help: “What about more shoe?” “Ew, apples? They don’t have any blood in them!” “Lemme give you a hand (waving around the human hand)”

The adventurer’s end of the bargain is fulfilled once they’ve tasted the finished meal and convince the devils that it is tasty. Characters that lie about the food’s taste must make a Charisma (Deception) check opposed to the fiends’ Wisdom (Insight) so the devils don’t catch them on it.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the party fulfills their end of the deal, the devils spike the food and drink with a potion of sleep before heading up to present the meal to Shilgengar. If the food is acceptable, the demonlord quickly consumes all of it and promptly goes to sleep. If unhappy with the food, however, Shilgengar enters a horrible rage and attacks the devils, which cause them to try and flee.

The charmbreaker devils defend themselves if the adventurers attack, giving up on attempts to bargain. If two devils are killed, the remaining devils attempt to flee into the dining hall (A5) and inform Shilgengar of intruders, joining him in battle.

AREA A7 – STABLES

The open-air stables are attached to the eastern wall of Mauer Estate. The corpse wagons brought back from the zombie horde are found here, most of them now empty. Four **zombies** (MM p311) are hauling the last corpses from the wagons into the estate through adjacent double doors into the dining hall (A5), dumping them on the floor for Ugbug and his helpers to sort out.

Like the other zombies outside, they are totally indifferent to the characters unless attacked. Adventurers can enter the dining hall from here without any hassle.

TREASURE

Amongst the leftovers in the wagons are three diamonds hidden in dirty rags (100 gp each); a *potion of flying* in a stoppered vial inside a corpse’s pant pocket; and 23 gp and 35 sp scattered atop the wagons.

AREA A8 – CELLAR

The cellar’s entrance juts out from the north wall of the estate. Wooden double doors lead down underneath the mansion.

A short flight of stone steps leads down into the cellar floor. Guttering torchlight casts long shadows on the arched stone ceiling. The east and west walls are lined

with five-foot-wide cells, each sealed with an iron barred door and fitted with a nasty heap of straw.

The central region of the room is a well-stocked torture chamber. Chains and ropes hang from a tangle of pulleys and hooks set in the ceiling, some ending in manacles and others in clamps or cruel hooks of their own. A rack and an iron maiden round out the chamber’s morbid furnishings.

On the southern wall, blocked by kegs and barrels, is a large wooden door reinforced and barred with thick iron. An eerie purple light seeps through the cracks and crevices of the door.

This chamber is where Siegfried keeps most of his prisoners for interrogation and future experiments. If any characters is captured in Mauer Estate, they eventually end up naked and imprisoned in one of these cells. Adding a prisoner NPC that has ties to a future adventure you have planned can be a great hook to move from this story to the next.

A **bearded devil** (MM p70) named Terilanyx and a **lemure** (MM p76) named “Nattdaymon” -- the only gibberish “word” it can say -- sit on a pile of loot comprised of all prisoners’ belongings while playing a card game. The bearded devil is obviously bored and frustrated at having the nearly brain-dead lemur as its only opponent, wishing it had a real challenge. A clever and persuasive character may be able to convince the devil into releasing him/her from the cell to play a game.

Cell Doors. The cell doors feature locks requiring thieves’ tools and a successful DC 13 Dexterity check to pick. The doors can also be wrenched open by brute force with a successful DC 22 Strength check.

HOSTAGE SITUATION

If adventurers come here to rescue an ally, consider having the imprisoned character used as a hostage by Terilanyx, perhaps already restrained on the rack. The devil threatens to kill the prisoner if the adventurers make a wrong move.

If the bearded devil has no hostages to leverage, it and the lemur fight to the best of their abilities.

DEVELOPMENTS

If a character is imprisoned here, they can either be freed by other party members, or by coming up with ways to free themselves.

The spooky southern door leads to the catacombs, which is an opportunity to continue beyond this adventure (see “Conclusion”). If they’re adamant about opening the door and you don’t wish it to lead anywhere, make it a small storage room with a **flameskull** (MM p134) instead.

TREASURE

The pile of loot that the lemur and bearded devil sat on has all of the imprisoned character's equipment along with the equipment of previous prisoners: amongst the junk are five javelins, two spears, a shortsword two longswords, a light crossbow, studded leathers, and two quivers holding twenty crossbow bolts each. There is one standout amongst the pile: *demonmail hauberk* (APPENDIX A).

Hidden inside the straw pile of an empty cell is a silver earring set with a tiny ruby (30gp) and a banded gold ring dotted with emeralds (50gp). Characters searching the straw pile finds them both with a DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check.

The barrels contain salted pork and beef, flour, sugar, apples, and ale.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 1,065 XP equally among the characters if the party defeats the lemur and bearded devil.

AREA A9 – TOWER STAIRCASE

A 10-foot wide, spiraling stone staircase starts at the main hall (A2) and goes up 50 feet to the alchemy lab (A10). Sconces along the wall hold burning torches, keeping the staircase brightly lit.

(Warning! Below is a deliciously evil trap that sadistic DMs will get a kick out of. However, if the characters are already at low health, it may be best to skip/nerf this trap as the results may be lethal.)

SLIP N' SLIDE OF DOOM

Mechanical trap

Of the 60 steps in the staircase, step 30 and 40 are both pressure plates. When 20 or more pounds of pressure are placed on either of this trap's pressure plates, a chain of events happen:

- all the stone steps in the staircase flip over, transforming into a ramp covered in slippery grease
- the sconces drop the burning torches, lighting the grease on fire
- finally, a hidden trapdoor in the ceiling at the top of the staircase opens, releasing a 10-foot diameter rolling sphere of solid stone down the ramp, picking up the flaming grease as it rolls so it becomes a fiery boulder of doom

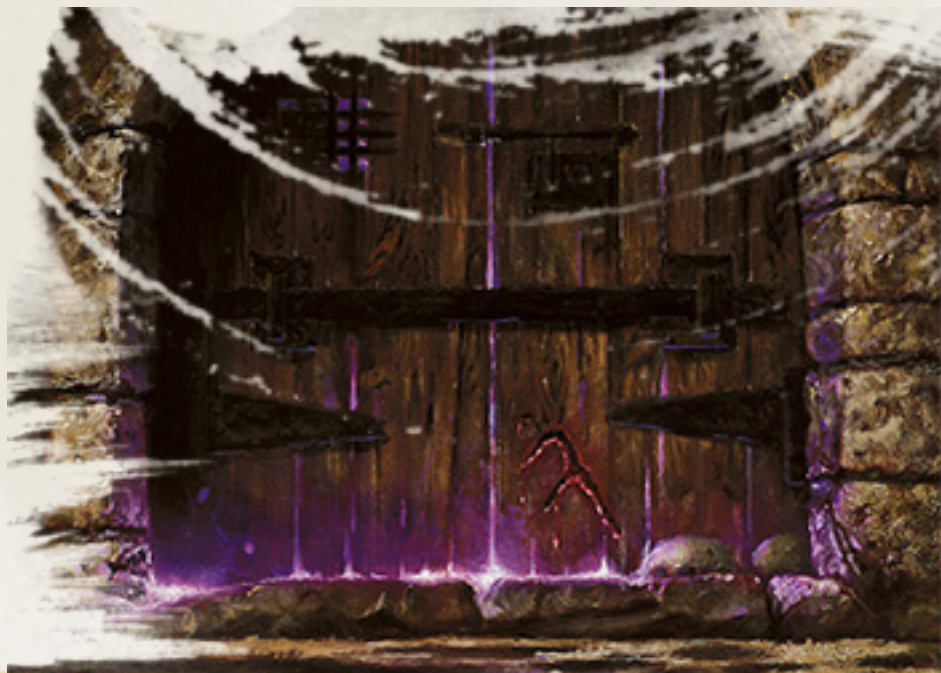
With a successful DC 13 Wisdom (Perception)

check, a character notices some grease seeping through the outline of each step, and scrapes along the walls. A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check spots a pressure plate or trapdoor if they have vision of it. A search of the floor accompanied by a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check reveals variations in the mortar and stone that betray the pressure plate's presence. The same check while inspecting the ceiling at the top of the stairs reveals the trapdoor. Wedging an iron spike or other object under the pressure plates prevents the trap from activating (or just step over it).

When the trap is activated, all creatures standing on the stairs must immediately make a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw as the staircase flips over and turns into a slippery ramp. On a failed save, the character falls prone and slides down the ramp, sliding 30 feet per round. A character that successfully saves may still need to make additional Dexterity saving throws if creatures above the character are sliding down into him/her.

After the stairs flip over into a greasy ramp, the sconces drop the torches, lighting the grease on fire. Characters standing in the flames take 1d4 fire damage at the start of each of its turns. Characters that fell prone and are drenched in grease catch fire, taking 1d6 fire damage of each of its turns and require a DC 13 Dexterity check to extinguish the flames.

Finally, once the stairs turn into a flaming greasy ramp, all affected creatures must roll initiative. The sphere rolls initiative with a +8 bonus. On its turn, it rolls 50 feet down the ramp. The sphere can move through creatures' spaces, and creatures can move through its space, treating it as difficult terrain. Whenever the sphere enters a creature's space or a creature enters its space while it's rolling, that creature must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 4d10 bludgeoning damage and an additional 1d6



fire damage and be knocked prone. The sphere stops when it hits a wall at the bottom of the staircase or similar barrier.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the trap is triggered, the staircase stays on fire until doused or naturally dies out after a minute once all the grease is burned. When the grease is cleared, walking up the ramp isn't difficult.

A triggered trap causes a big ruckus, informing Siegfried of intruders.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 1,800 XP equally among the characters if the party disarms, purposefully avoids, or triggers the slip n' slide of doom.

AREA A10 – ALCHEMY LAB

At the top of the tower is the alchemy lab. Siegfried has spent the last few months here, working relentlessly day and night on his experiments. His foul work has attracted a small following of demons that are interested in seeing his goals realized. The fiends aid in his work and whisper dark secrets in his ear, pushing the alchemist towards greater acts of depravity.

Siegfried is currently at the cusp of completing his grandest achievement yet: he is about to give life to a new, immensely powerful being of his own design (The Egg; see below), which the alchemist hopes will lead his army of undead against the vampire families.

GALVANIZING LIFE

To wake his new creations, the mad scientist must bestow upon them "the spark of life," which requires a tremendous amount of power.

Siegfried has built a complex device called a *galvanizer* -- a machine of sprawling tubes, wires, coils, and lightning rods that covers his entire lab from floor to rooftop -- to provide this power. Siegfried uses the *galvanizer* to create the raging storm overhead, collecting the electricity from the lightning strikes to "shock" his creations to life.

THE EGG

An open ceiling hatch exposes the laboratory to the raging storm above. A metal platform is raised up to the opening, with a huge, slimy purple egg strapped on top of the platform. The Egg rhythmically expands and contracts like a beating heart.

Attacking The Egg. The Egg has 60 hit points. If attacked, it releases a psychic scream of pain, immediately alerting everyone in the laboratory.

Hatching The Egg. A lightning vane (fancy lightning rod) attached to the platform can be raised up into the storm, channeling lightning strikes into The Egg. Raising the lightning vane this way requires an action to turn a crank. Each round the lightning vane is raised, lightning strikes it, jolting The Egg. After five lightning strikes, The Egg hatches into **The Thing** (APPENDIX B) ([PICTURE](#)).

The Thing's immediate desire is to escape the laboratory. It only attacks people in its way, including Siegfried. If reduced to half its hit points, The Thing tears off the roof and attempts to flee into the wilderness.

ENTERING THE LABORATORY

The adventurers are most likely to enter through the staircase (A9) that connects the lab to the main hall. Alternatively, they may be entering through the open hatch in the ceiling, or up the dumbwaiter (A5). Whichever way they enter, read or paraphrase the following as their first glance inside:

The misty interior of the laboratory glows with a flickering radiance and hums with power. Metal rods and spheres jutting from the floors and ceilings are awash in electricity. A jungle of glass tubes and metal wires sprawl all over the floor, walls, and ceiling, connecting the strange contraptions found here with everything else.

An open ceiling hatch exposes the laboratory to the raging storm above. A metal platform is raised up to the opening, with a huge, slimy purple egg strapped on top of it.

The most notable features of the room to spot are:

- Large glass incubators containing bulky malformed humanoids floating inside luminous greenish-blue liquids; these are **schmelzmen** (APPENDIX B)
- A metal platform with a humanoid figure lying down on it, hidden under a bloodstained sheet; this is a **flesh golem** (MM p169)
- A second metal platform adorned with lightning rods, raised up to the ceiling hatch and exposed to the thunderstorm above; it holds The Egg

Siegfried is too engrossed in his work to be bothered keeping an eye on the rest of the estate. If the adventurers managed to reach the laboratory without triggering the trap in the staircase (A9), no one warned Siegfried of intruders (A5), and The Egg doesn't scream, use the *Caught Unaware* scenario below. If Siegfried is warned of the party's presence, use the *Ready for Action* scenario instead.

CAUGHT UNAWARE



Siegfried (APPENDIX B) paces through the laboratory, making sure everything is running smoothly and he barking orders to his homunculus assistant, **Oglor** (APPENDIX B). Qarr, a **quasit** (MM 63), observes invisibly from a corner. The fiend is alert for trouble and actively scans the area (Passive Perception 15); ironically, Qarr is rather skittish around creations that have a habit of randomly springing to life and causing the poor quasit a bit of a scare.

A man in a long white coat strides excitedly through the laboratory, flipping switches and turning knobs with his thick rubber gloves, pausing only for a moment to watch their effects. He barks orders across the room at small green-skinned humanoid, who's "head" is a giant eyeball encased in a bronze helmet with a large telescope lens to peer out of. "The storm is ready to harness! Oglor, increase the rotational speed of the flux capacitor to eighty percent!"

The adventurers have a surprise round if none of the lab's occupants notice them.

READY FOR ACTION

If alerted to the adventurer's presence ahead of time, then Siegfried, Qarr, and Oglor are on alert for intruders, each of them gaining +5 to their Passive Perception to catch anyone trying to sneak in.

COMBAT!

Siegfried is convinced that the adventurers are either vampires or servants of them. It would take a tremendous effort to talk him out of a fight. He starts the fight with

mage armor already cast on himself.

Flipping Switches. Once combat begins, Siegfried's primary goal is to distract the adventurers long enough for The Egg to hatch. He runs across the lab to flip two switches: the first animates the **schmelzmen** and the second animates the **flesh golem**. He can flip one switch as per turn as a free action. He prefers to start combat by casting *invisibility*, since flipping switches does not break the spell.

Here is a general sequence of actions that Siegfried will take during combat, along with sample dramatic banter the mad scientist likes to engage in. Siegfried in this **crazed** state is based heavily off [Victor Frankenstein](#) in popular culture.

The mad scientist also engages in dramatic banter:

- **1st Round:** Siegfried casts *invisibility* on himself and taunts the adventurers. He flips a switch, sending a pulse of electricity that shatters the incubators, animating three **schmelzmen** (APPENDIX B) that immediately attack the party
- *"So the Voldarens have managed to breach my sanctum. You've come just in time, bloodsuckers: witness the fruits of my labor!"*
- **2nd Round:** Siegfried flips the second switch, sending a massive pulse of electricity that animates the **narstad scrapper** (APPENDIX B), which immediately attacks the party. Siegfried also instructs Oglor to raise the lightning vane.
- *"Behold! I create life with the flip of a switch! I am a GOD!"*
- *"The storm has reached peak potency! Oglor, raise the lightning vane!"*

Siegfried only engages the adventurers directly if they attack The Egg or are clearly gaining the upper hand in the battle. Siegfried fearlessly defends his life's work, casting his most powerful spells to fight off the adventurers and fighting to the death if he must.

"NO! I have worked too hard to see my dreams ruined by the likes of you! I will have my revenge!"

Oglor raises the lightning vane when commanded to by turning a crank (see "The Egg"). Oglor avoids combat as long as no one interferes with its task.

Qarr is not a fighter and is content to observe while invisible.

DEVELOPMENTS

This battle is quite dangerous. In the event that the party is defeated, Siegfried imprisons the surviving characters in the cellar (A8) for future interrogation and experiments.

If defeated and taken captive, Siegfried's madness cannot be fixed in an instant (though a *wish* spell or similar powerful magic might). Bringing him back to sanity is certainly possible, but the healing process takes time and effort. The best immediate effect an adventurer can hope for is to at least calm him down.

Oglor is loyal to Siegfried, its master. However, if Siegfried is slain, it views his killer as its new master. Oglor can't speak, but it tries to convey its wish to serve through gestures.

Qarr, while seemingly working under Siegfried as well, actually serves a more powerful archdemon; who that mysterious patron is up to you. The quasit was tasked to corrupt Siegfried by this patron. At your discretion, Qarr may offer to serve as a familiar to one of the party members, tempting the character with power/info/wealth as appropriate, with a hidden agenda to keep tabs on the party's movements. Or the quasit may try to escape and inform the mysterious patron on the adventurers' actions – up to you!

Should the tubes, wires, coils, and other machinery that the galvanizer consists of be significantly damaged from area of effect spells or direct attacks (your discretion), or if the adventurers manage to switch it off, then the thunderstorm disperses and the radiant wards surrounding the tower fade away.

If you wish to use the NPC [Sir Delandel, the Undead Paladin](#), characters can find him trapped inside a steel incubator. Siegfried found Delandel in Mauer Estate and hooked him up to the galvanizer; he is unwilling the source for the protective radiant wards that surround the tower.

TREASURE

Siegfried wears the *electric recombobulator* (APPENDIX A) and has one scroll of each of the following: *alarm*, *catapult*, *false life*, *mage armor*, *mirror image*, and *lightning bolt*. In addition, Siegfried carries the broken missing piece of the *Strionic Resonator* and a key to a chest.

A chest is tucked underneath Siegfried's work desk. The chest's padlock can be picked using thieves' tools with a successful DC 20 Dexterity check. However, the lock is rigged with a poison needle trap that triggers if a character isn't pressing down a concealed button on the side of the chest while opening the chest. The needle and button can both be found with a successful DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check and can be disarmed with a successful DC 15 Dexterity check. A creature triggering the needle trap is injected with wyvern poison

and must make a DC 13 Constitution saving throw, taking 5d6 poison damage on a failed save, or half as much on a successful one.

The chest contains a silver locket with a picture of a young woman inside (Katarina), a silver torc with soaring herons (80 gp), six moonstones of 50 gp each, 200 sp, 90 gp, and 10 pp.

A thorough search of the room yields several letters to Siegfried from Geraif, a cousin and infamous stitcher currently operating in the Moorland. Geraif's letters reveals an exchange on necro-alchemy information between the two. In the last dated letter, Geraif praises his cousin's brilliance, stating that he put into practice Siegfried's blueprints for a modern "goliath skaab" and it turned out "better than I could ever have hoped." Geraif has named this creation Grimgrin, and invites Siegfried to join him and his sister in Gavony, where they plan to march on Thraben itself soon. If the characters deliver these letters to the proper authorities in Gavony, award the party 4,000 XP.

The laboratory is littered with specialized alchemical tools and devices, glass jars full of pickled organs, anatomical charts for both human and beast, rune-engraved skeletal remains, dozens of tools for inscribing runes on brass and copper plates, and on. In total, the laboratory would be worth 80,000 gp to necro-alchemists in Nephalia, but moving this equipment is highly impracticable and dismantling it by someone not trained in alchemy can easily destroy the fragile equipment.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 1,800 XP equally among the characters if the party defeats Siegfried and his minions. Award an additional 500 XP if the characters find the missing piece of the *Strionic Resonator*.

MILESTONE: LEVEL 5!

If you are using Milestone Experience, then the characters attain 5th level as you conclude this adventure!

CONCLUSION

With hard work and a little luck, the adventurers have defeated Siegfried and undone his destructive plots. All in Stensia will take note of their deeds: the humans of Stensia shall be grateful for years to come, and the vampire families will surely take note of these new heroes as well.

By the end of the adventure, the characters should be 5th level. If your players wish to continue playing their characters, you can use the contents of this setting to